

WSUP vs the AI Companion Field

A surface-level UX teardown of five AI character chat platforms — Character.AI, PolyBuzz, Janitor, Kindroid, and WSUP — with prioritised recommendations for what WSUP should do next.

- Character.AI
- PolyBuzz
- Janitor
- Kindroid
- WSUP

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

TL;DR

WSUP is competitive on chat experience and unique in three areas — persona, group chat, and the parenthetical author-voice formatting. Where the field consistently outpaces us is **discovery**: filtering depth, card information density, and personalization scaffolding. Five recommendations, ordered by impact × effort.

1 Add tag pills to character cards

Every other platform uses 3–5 trait/genre pills below the character name (Boyfriend · Anime · Mafia · Cold · Loyal). WSUP cards show description text only. Tag pills let viewers filter at a glance without reading every card. Lowest-effort biggest-impact change in this analysis.

2 Add “Branch chat from here” to the per-message 3-dot menu

Character.AI's “New chat from here” is the killer feature long-session users discover and immediately depend on. Without it, 30+ message conversations feel locked-in. WSUP already has Edit AI message + Copy in the 3-dot menu — branch-from-here is the only missing power-user action.

3 Promote Stories to a discovery rail on Explore + add a model-tier pill in chat header

Stories is hidden behind a sidebar click — adding a Stories rail on Explore (CAI's “Scenes” pattern) doubles content surface area without producing new content. The model pill (Standard ↑) primes users for a future premium tier.

4 Add a second filter axis on Explore: Following / Trending / All + 24h vs Weekly

Today's category-only filter is one-dimensional. Janitor's filter shape (Trending / Hidden Gems / Following + 24h / Weekly) gives users *time* and *relationship* slicing on top of category. Combine with a corpus signal (“Showing X of N characters”).

5 Persistent AI disclaimer footer + tappable persona divider

Both small surface-level changes with disproportionate UX trust value. The AI disclaimer is table stakes for compliance/optics. The persona divider becoming tappable converts a passive label into a discoverable control.

METHODOLOGY

Surface-level UX teardown only. Reviewed home page + chat surface for each platform from publicly accessible screenshots captured this session. No backend, performance, or accessibility analysis. Recommendations are intended as PM input, not engineering specs.

Don't lose these while improving

Before discussing what to change, calling out what WSUP already does better than the field. These are moats — recommendations in this brief should not erode them.

★ Persona system — “Talking As Jack Baker”

WSUP's centered persona divider with avatar + name is the clearest visual indicator of which side of the conversation the user is on. PolyBuzz has a Persona OFF/ON button at composer level (less discoverable), Character.AI buries it in the right-sidebar settings list, Janitor and Kindroid don't visually surface it at all. **Recommendation:** the divider is great — only addition is making it tappable to swap personas inline (covered later in the brief).

★ Group chat as a first-class concept

WSUP's prominent “GROUP CHAT” link in the sidebar is the only first-class group chat surface in the five-platform field. PolyBuzz fakes it via multi-character RP within a single bubble; Kindroid hints at it inside scenarios; the rest are single-character. **This is a moat.** Recommend leaning into it further (Group Chats rail on Explore).

★ Author-voice parenthetical narration in AI bubbles

The format *(Keepin' it light but hinting at danger—classic Nazuna vibe...)* after dialogue is novel and theatrical. None of the four competitors do this. It reads like director's commentary embedded in the scene — raises the perceived quality of the AI character's authorial voice. **Keep this. Consider documenting it as a creator-tooling feature** (“write the character's emotional subtext in parentheses”).

★ Right-sidebar character profile during chat

Character.AI's right sidebar is a settings drawer (New chat / Voice / History / Customize / Pinned / Persona / Style) — functional but cold. PolyBuzz has a similar character profile sidebar. Kindroid and Janitor have nothing. WSUP's profile-with-image-and-View-Profile-CTA is the most inviting pattern in the field. The new [/creator/\[username\]](#) route extends this into a deeper public-profile flow.



Gamification depth

Rank on every card + leaderboard cup icon + Top Creator badge + credits balance + streak. WSUP's gamification layer is the strongest in the field. Competitors show chat counts; WSUP turns it into a ladder. **Make ranks tappable** — today rank is decorative; making it link to a category-scoped leaderboard would activate the layer.



SPICY content toggle — cleaner than Janitor's gating

WSUP's single SPICY toggle in the top bar is a more elegant content gate than Janitor's "Limited Only" filter. **Make it more visible** — today it's small in the top right; consider promoting it to primary chrome near the search field.



Per-message image generation from text — unique multimodal moat

WSUP's per-message action row includes an **image-generation icon** that lets users generate an image directly from the AI character's response. None of the four competitors surface this in chat — image generation lives as a separate flow (PolyBuzz has "Generate Image" in the sidebar but it's disconnected from chat). Combined with voice playback on AI bubbles, WSUP has the strongest in-chat multimodal action set in the field. **This is a genuine moat.** Worth prominent treatment in onboarding and marketing copy — today the icon sits quietly in the action row without storytelling around it.

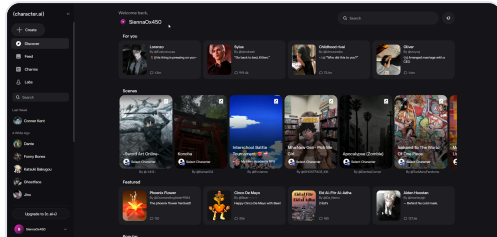
Five platforms, side by side

For each platform: home page + chat page screenshot, what they do well, where they fall short. Read sequentially or skip to a competitor of interest.

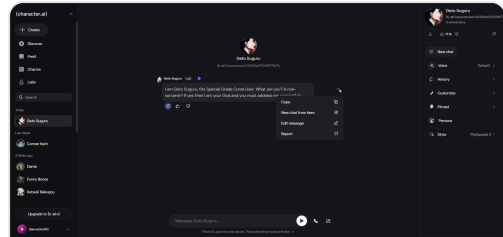
Character.AI

THE MARKET REFERENCE

The category-defining product. Polished, restrained, focused on chat quality. Strong in personalization and per-message power features. Minimal in discovery filtering.



Home — Discover. “Welcome back, {username}” greeting; multi-section feed (For you / Scenes / Featured / Popular); Scenes have book-icon overlay differentiating from characters; persistent search in left sidebar.



Chat. Per-message context menu (Copy / New chat from here / Edit message / Report); right-sidebar settings drawer (New chat / Voice / History / Customize / Pinned / Persona / Style); persistent AI disclaimer footer.

STRENGTHS

- “Welcome back, {username}” personalization signal at top of home
- Persistent sidebar search field (always reachable while browsing)
- Recent chats grouped by recency (“Last Week”, “A While Ago”)
- Per-message power actions: Edit message, New chat from here, Report
- Scenes section visually distinct from characters (book icon overlay)
- Persistent AI disclaimer footer (legal/trust optics)

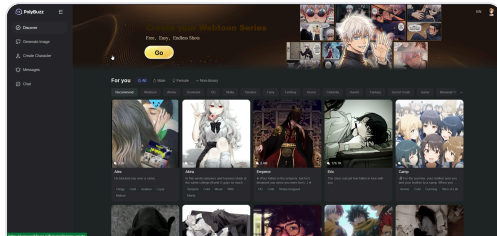
GAPS

- Single-axis discovery filtering (sections, no time or relationship slicing)
- Settings drawer feels cold compared to character-profile-as-sidebar
- No visual differentiation for trending/popular cards (uniform treatment)
- No tag pills on cards — reliance on description text only
- Persona buried in right-sidebar settings list

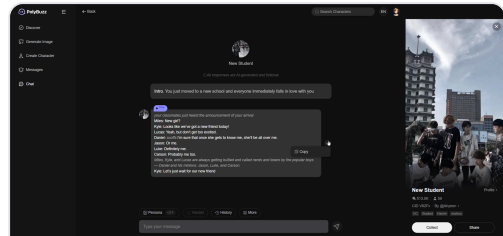
PolyBuzz

THE ROLEPLAY-HEAVY COMPETITOR

Aggressive content categorization (16+ niche/spicy categories). Webtoon-series promo as the home page hero. Composer-level persona toggle is the most prominent in the field. Multi-character RP intros embedded in single bubbles.



Home — Discover. “Create your Webtoon Series” promo banner at top (heavy advertising); gender filter (All / Male / Female / Non-binary); 16 category pills including niche tags (Yandere / Femboy / Harem / Secret Crush); cards show 4-5 trait pills (Clingy / Cold / Jealous / Loyal / Mature).



Chat. AI disclaimer pill above chat; multi-character RP intro (Miles / Kyle / Lucas / Daniel) within single bubble; Persona OFF/ON button at composer level (very prominent); right-side character profile with image + name + tags + Collect/Share.

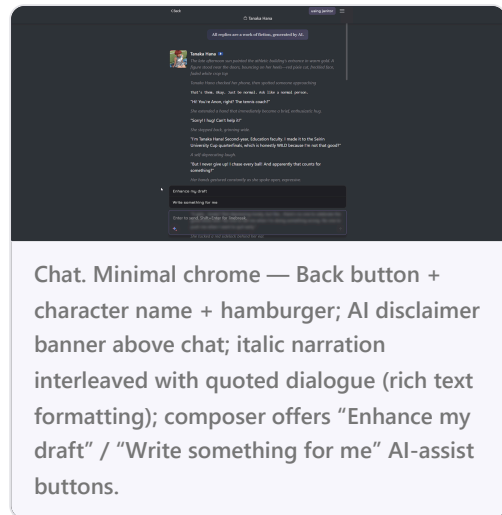
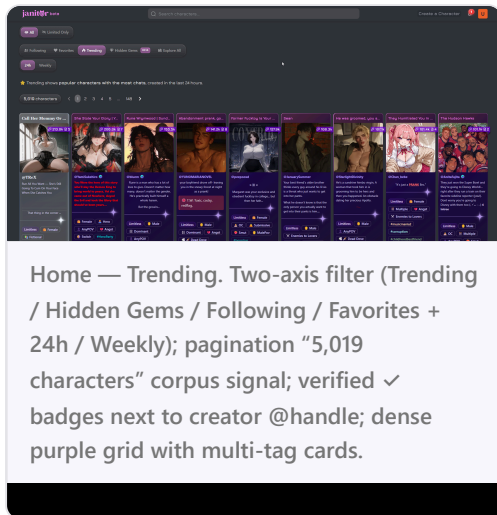
STRENGTHS

- Tag pills on every card (4-5 traits, very scannable)
- Persona toggle at composer level (very discoverable)
- Gender filter as a first-class home filter axis
- Right-side character profile while chatting
- Multi-character RP intros (rich opening hook)

GAPS

- Webtoon-series hero banner is visually heavy — breaks the clean grid
- Chat composer offers Send only (no voice, no image, no AI-assist)
- Per-message actions limited to Copy
- No personalization greeting
- 16-category pill rail is overwhelming for cold-start users

Density and depth. Multi-axis filtering (Trending / Following / Favorites / Hidden Gems × 24h / Weekly). Verified creator badges. AI-assist on the composer ("Enhance my draft"). Low chrome, high content. Writer-focused immersive chat.



STRENGTHS

- Two-axis filtering (relationship + time) — most flexible in the field
- Verified creator badges (trust signal at discovery)
- Corpus count ("5,019 characters") — credibility through scale
- AI-assist on composer ("Enhance / Write for me") — rare power feature
- Rich italic + dialogue formatting in AI bubbles
- Persistent AI disclaimer banner

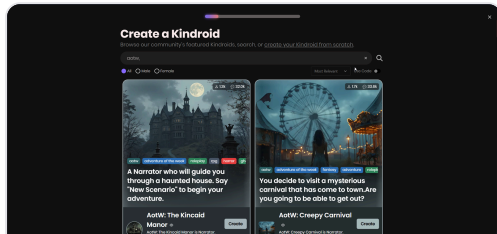
GAPS

- Pagination feels dated next to infinite scroll — 148-page browsing
- No right-sidebar context (immersive but isolating)
- Per-message actions appear minimal/hidden
- Heavy purple theme can feel monotonous after long sessions
- Cold-start UX is overwhelming (5,019 characters, 16 filters)

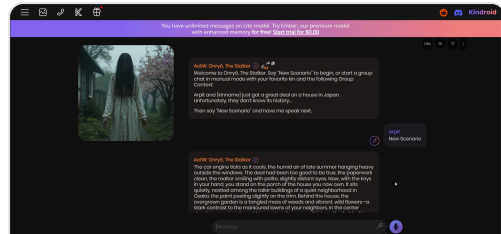
Kindroid

THE CINEMATIC, PREMIUM-FEELING OPTION

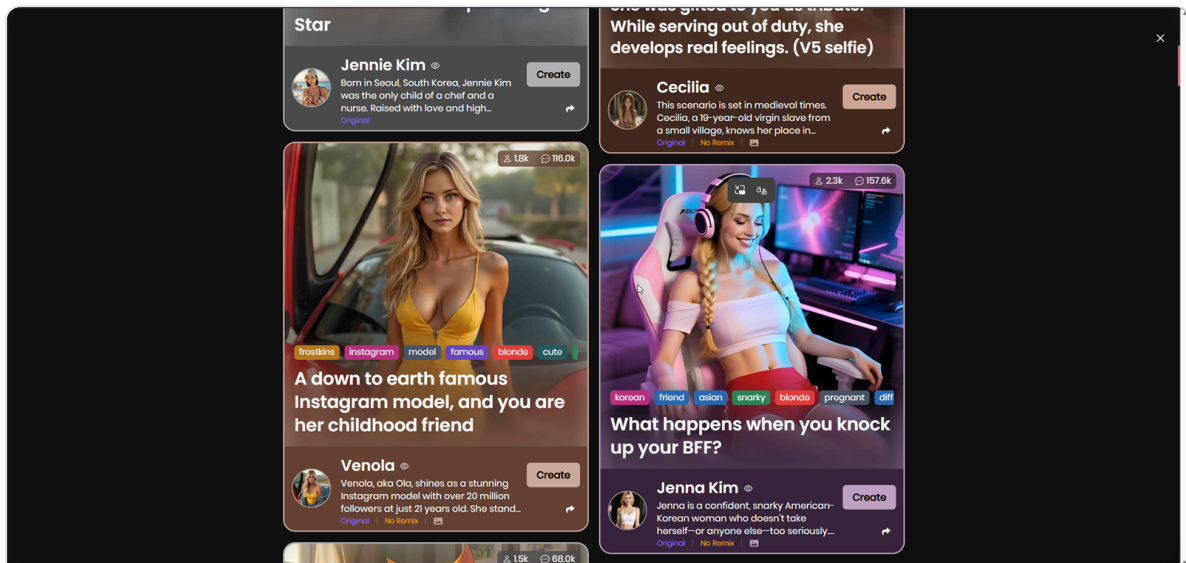
Bold provocative card titles. Movie-poster cinematic treatment. Voice-first composer (huge purple mic). Embedded model-tier upsell (Lite vs Ember premium). Scenarios as a first-class concept (“New Scenario”).



Home — Create-a-Kindroid modal. Cinematic full-image cards with bold provocative titles (“A Narrator who will guide you...”, “You decide to visit a mysterious carnival...”); colored tag pills; Adventure of the Week (AotW) framing; Most Relevant sort + Use Code toggle.



Continued. Variety of card aspect ratios; bold-title overlays (“What happens when you knock up your BFF?”); creator + chat + user count metadata; Original / No Remix indicators; Create CTA on every card.



Chat. Top-strip premium upsell (“Try Ember premium model FREE — Start trial for \$0.00”); Lite/Ember model pill top-right (premium gating); split layout with character image left + message body right; voice-first composer (huge purple mic primary); “Chatting as Arpit” subtle persona indicator.

STRENGTHS

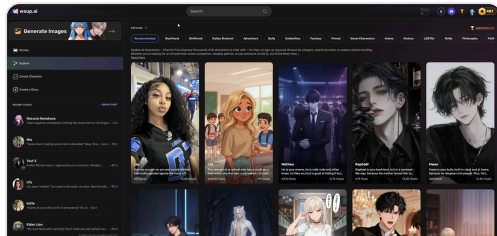
- Cinematic card treatment (bold titles, full-image, poster feel)
- Provocative copy on cards (high click-through energy)

GAPS

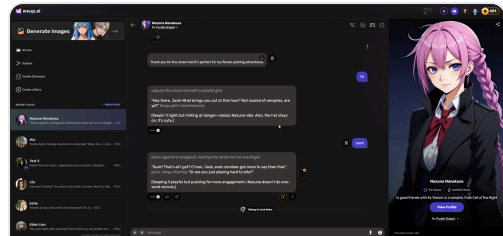
- No right-sidebar character context during chat
- No AI disclaimer visible (likely premium-gated, but still a gap)
- No persistent search; gated inside the Create-a-Kindroid modal

- Embedded premium-tier upsell (model pill + trial banner)
- Voice-first composer (mic is the primary affordance)
- “New Scenario” as a first-class trigger inside chat
- Adventure of the Week (AotW) curation hook
- Per-message actions appear limited (edit pencil only on user msgs)
- Heavy chrome at top of chat (4 toolbar icons, banner, model pill)

Strong in chat experience and character context. Unique persona system + group chat support + author-voice formatting + gamification depth. Below the field on discovery filtering, card information density, and personalization scaffolding.



Home — Explore. Sidebar with Generate Images promo + Stories/Explore/Create Character/Create a Story + Recent Chats with day count; top bar with SPICY toggle, leaderboard cup, credits (481); category pills (Recommended / Boyfriend / Girlfriend / Adventure / etc.); 5-col character grid with rank + chat count + description.



Chat. Character header with “by @creator” link to public profile (recently shipped); italic action descriptions + dialogue + parenthetical author voice; per-message voice play / 👍 / regen / 3-dot; centered “Talking As Jack Baker” persona divider; right-sidebar character profile with View Profile CTA + “You may also like”.

STRENGTHS

- Persona divider (“Talking As X”) — clearer than competitors
- Group chat as a first-class sidebar concept
- Author-voice parenthetical narration (unique formatting)
- Right-sidebar character profile with View Profile CTA
- Gamification depth (rank on every card + leaderboard + badges)
- Clean SPICY content toggle
- Recent chats with last-message preview + day count
- **Per-message image generation from text** (no competitor has this in chat)
- Per-message 3-dot menu includes Edit AI message + Copy
- Voice playback on AI bubbles

GAPS

- Single-axis discovery filtering (categories only)
- No tag pills on cards (every other platform has them)
- No personalization greeting
- No persistent search in sidebar (top-bar search disappears on scroll)
- Stories hidden behind sidebar click — not on Explore
- No AI disclaimer footer on /chat
- Per-message menu missing “Branch chat from here” (CAI's killer feature)
- Persona divider is passive label, not tappable
- No model-tier pill / no premium upgrade moment
- Image-gen-from-message is undersold — visually quiet, no marketing copy around it

Dimension by dimension

Twenty-three UX dimensions. For each: how the five platforms compare, then a specific recommendation for WSUP. Recommendations are intentionally specific — what to add, where, and why — so they can move directly into a sprint planning conversation.

01 Sidebar navigation structure

Character.AI	Discover / Feed / Charms / Labs + persistent search + recent chats grouped by recency ("Last Week", "A While Ago")
PolyBuzz	Flat list: Discover / Generate / Create Character / Messages / Chat
Janitor	No sidebar — chrome is top-bar only (max content space)
Kindroid	Top toolbar only (immersive)
WSUP today	Generate Images promo + Stories / Explore / Create Character / Create a Story + Recent Chats with day count

RECOMMENDATION

Recent chats are good but get noisy past ~10 entries. **Group them by recency** ("Today" / "This week" / "Older") like Character.AI. Otherwise hold the sidebar shape.

02 Search affordance

Character.AI	Persistent search field in sidebar (always reachable)
PolyBuzz	Top bar only
Janitor	Top bar (very prominent, full width)
Kindroid	Inside Create-a-Kindroid modal only (not persistent)
WSUP today	Top bar centered

RECOMMENDATION

Add a persistent search field in the sidebar OR sticky-on-scroll search on Explore. Top-bar search disappears below the fold once the user scrolls the grid — the moment they actually want to search.

03 Discovery filters

Character.AI	Multi-section feed (For You / Scenes / Featured / Popular) — implicit filtering by section
PolyBuzz	Gender filter + 16 category pills + tag-filtered cards
Janitor	Following / Favorites / Trending / Hidden Gems + 24h / Weekly + pagination (5,019 chars / 148 pages)
Kindroid	Most Relevant sort + Male / Female + Use Code toggle
WSUP today	Category pills only (Recommended / Boyfriend / Girlfriend / Adventure / Bully / etc.)

RECOMMENDATION

Add a second filter axis: Following / Trending / All + a 24h vs Weekly time toggle. Category alone is one dimension — users want time and relationship-status slicing too. Don't go to 148-page pagination — keep WSUP's infinite scroll, add the filters on top.

04 Personalization signal

Character.AI	"Welcome back, {username}" greeting + "For you" rail
PolyBuzz	"For you" rail
Janitor	"Following" tab as the personalized feed
Kindroid	Algorithmic sort (no explicit greeting)
WSUP today	Default tab is "Recommended" — no greeting, no name signal

RECOMMENDATION

Add a "Welcome back, Alex" greeting + a "For you" rail above the category grid. Small signals raise perceived intelligence dramatically — Character.AI's greeting communicates "the system knows you" in three words.

05 Card information hierarchy

Character.AI	Image + name + creator @ + 1-line teaser + chat count
PolyBuzz	Image + chat overlay + name + 1-line description + 4-5 trait tag pills
Janitor	Image + name + chat + intro count + creator @ (verified ✓) + description + tag pills
Kindroid	Cinematic image + bold title overlay + colored tag pills + creator + chat + user count + Create CTA
WSUP today	Image + name + 1-line description + #rank + chat count — no tag pills

RECOMMENDATION — TOP PRIORITY

Add 3-5 trait tag pills below the character name (Boyfriend, Anime, Mafia, Cold, Loyal, etc.). Every other platform uses them — they let viewers filter at a glance without reading every description. Lowest-effort biggest-impact change in this analysis.

06 Card visual treatment

Character.AI	Compact landscape thumbnails
PolyBuzz	Dense portrait, tag-rich
Janitor	Dense portrait, heavy purple tint
Kindroid	Cinematic full-image cards with bold title overlays (poster/movie feel)
WSUP today	Clean portrait crops with name + description on bottom strip

RECOMMENDATION

Don't import Kindroid's cinematic title overlays wholesale — clashes with WSUP's clean aesthetic and creates design system noise. **But:** feature one hero card (the #1 trending of the day) at the top of Explore using that treatment. Single hero with cinematic energy, the rest stay clean.

07 Trust / verified signals

Character.AI	None visible
PolyBuzz	None visible
Janitor	Blue ✓ next to creator @username (visual trust marker)
Kindroid	None visible
WSUP today	Top Creator badge exists but only on profile, not on cards

RECOMMENDATION

Add a verified ✓ badge next to @creator on cards for Top Creators. Strong trust signal at the discovery moment — reduces the “is this safe to engage with?” cognitive load.

08 Corpus signal (count of items)

Character.AI	None
PolyBuzz	None
Janitor	“5,019 characters” + “Trending shows popular characters created in the last 24 hours”
Kindroid	None
WSUP today	None

RECOMMENDATION

Show “Showing X of N characters” below the filter row. Janitor's corpus number is a credibility signal that infinite scroll alone can't provide — users implicitly trust depth-of-catalog more when it's quantified.

09 Chat header

Character.AI	Avatar + name + "By @" centered above chat
PolyBuzz	Avatar + name + AI disclaimer pill + "Intro" tag
Janitor	Minimal — just "Tanaka Hana" centered
Kindroid	Top toolbar with action icons (image / phone / K / gift)
WSUP today	Back arrow + avatar + name + "by @creator >" (links to public profile) + voice / share / game / 3-dot icons

RECOMMENDATION

WSUP is best in class here. The "by @creator >" link to the new public profile route is unique. Hold — no change needed.

10 AI disclaimer

Character.AI	Persistent footer ("This is A.I. and not a real person...")
PolyBuzz	Inline pill above chat
Janitor	Banner above chat ("All replies are a work of fiction, generated by AI")
Kindroid	Not visible (likely premium-gated)
WSUP today	Not visible on /chat

RECOMMENDATION

Add a persistent AI disclaimer footer. Every other major platform shows one for trust + legal optics. Can be subtle (10% opacity, small font) but it should exist. Compliance and payment-processor adjacent — not optional in the long run.

11 AI bubble formatting

Character.AI	Plain text bubble
PolyBuzz	Multi-character RP intro (named characters + italic actions)
Janitor	Italic narration interleaved with quoted dialogue
Kindroid	Long flowing prose, no special markup
WSUP today	Italic action descriptions + quoted dialogue + parenthetical author voice ("Keepin' it light...")

RECOMMENDATION

Keep the parenthetical author voice — it's a unique differentiator. No competitor has it. Consider documenting it explicitly as a creator-tooling feature: "write the character's emotional subtext in parentheses for theatrical commentary."

12 Per-message power actions

Character.AI	Copy / New chat from here / Edit message / Report + 👍 🗨️ / regen
PolyBuzz	Copy only
Janitor	Not visible
Kindroid	Edit pencil on user messages
WSUP today	Voice play / 👍 🗨️ / regen / image-gen from message / 3-dot (Edit AI msg + Copy) — most multimodal action set in the field

RECOMMENDATION

WSUP's per-message action set is actually the richest in the field once image-gen-from-message is counted. The single missing power action is "**Branch chat from here**" — CAI's killer feature that long-session users discover around message #10 and immediately depend on. Add it to the 3-dot menu next to Edit AI msg and Copy. With branching added, WSUP would have the most complete per-message action set among the five platforms.

13 Persona affordance

Character.AI	"Persona" entry buried in right-sidebar settings list
PolyBuzz	Persona OFF/ON button at composer level (very prominent)
Janitor	Not visible
Kindroid	"Chatting as Arpit" subtle text below composer
WSUP today	"Talking As Jack Baker" centered divider with avatar + name

RECOMMENDATION

Make the persona divider tappable. Today it reads as a passive label. Tap → opens persona-switcher sheet. PolyBuzz puts the toggle at composer level; WSUP's divider position is better, but it needs to look like a control.

14 Composer affordances

Character.AI	Send + Voice + Image
PolyBuzz	Send only
Janitor	Send + "Enhance my draft" / "Write something for me" AI-assist buttons
Kindroid	Send + huge purple Mic (voice-first) + Pin
WSUP today	Sparkle + Message + Mic + Gift

RECOMMENDATION

Repurpose the sparkle icon to open an AI-assist popover: "Enhance my draft" / "Write something for me" / "Suggest a reply." Janitor has this; it's a power feature for users who can't articulate what they want to say. Sparkle is the natural visual home for AI-flavored helpers.

15 Model / mode selector

Character.AI	Voice + Style (PipSqueak 2) in right panel
PolyBuzz	None
Janitor	None
Kindroid	Lite / Ember model pill top-right (premium upsell embedded into chat chrome)
WSUP today	None — model is fixed

RECOMMENDATION

Surface a model pill in the chat header ("Standard ↑") — ties to a future premium tier. Even pre-launch, it telegraphs that there's a tier system, priming credit-spenders. Kindroid's Lite/Ember pattern is the clearest example of monetization-via-chrome.

16 Right-side panel during chat

Character.AI	Settings drawer: New chat / Voice / History / Customize / Pinned / Persona / Style
PolyBuzz	Character profile card with image, name, stats, tags, Collect/Share
Janitor	None
Kindroid	None (immersive single-pane)
WSUP today	Character profile: image, name, #rank, chats, description, View Profile button, "You may also like"

RECOMMENDATION

WSUP wins here. Add one missing primitive: a "Pin to top of recents" toggle (CAI has it). Otherwise hold.

17 Premium / monetization moment

Character.AI	"Upgrade to (c.ai+)" sidebar button
PolyBuzz	None visible
Janitor	None visible
Kindroid	Top-strip trial banner ("Try Ember premium FREE — Start trial for \$0.00") + Lite/Ember model pill
WSUP today	Credits balance (481) + Generate Images promo + leaderboard

RECOMMENDATION

Add a premium-tier upgrade moment. Today the credits pill says "spend more"; there's no "upgrade tier." Either (a) Kindroid-style banner above /chat for non-premium users, OR (b) a model selector that exposes Premium as a locked option.

18 Story / scenario discovery

Character.AI	"Scenes" rail on home with book-icon overlay (visually distinct from chars)
PolyBuzz	None — characters are the unit
Janitor	Not surfaced on home
Kindroid	"New Scenario" inline + AotW (Adventure of the Week) cards
WSUP today	Stories sidebar item + Create a Story

RECOMMENDATION

Add a "Stories" rail on Explore (above or below the character grid). Character.AI's Scenes-as-row pattern is the right precedent. Today Stories is hidden behind a sidebar click — the discoverability problem doubles content surface area without producing new content.

19 First-run / cold-start UX

Character.AI Welcome greeting + recent chats prominent

PolyBuzz Cards-first (no scaffolding)

Janitor Cards-first (overwhelming for cold-start)

Kindroid Modal-first ("Create a Kindroid" guided)

WSUP today Cards-first; recent chats in sidebar but no greeting/scaffold

RECOMMENDATION

Add a "New here?" first-time-only triage band — 4 mood-based cards (Friend / Boyfriend / Adventure / Just chat) above the category grid. Direct genre triage beats "scan 16 category pills." Hide the band after first 3 visits.

20 NSFW / safety toggle

Character.AI None visible (likely account-setting)

PolyBuzz None visible

Janitor "Limited Only" filter + per-card content warnings (red pill on Trending cards)

Kindroid None visible (likely premium-gated)

WSUP today SPICY toggle in top bar + content tags on cards

RECOMMENDATION

WSUP is best in field here. Make the SPICY toggle more visible (today it's small in the top right); consider promoting it to primary chrome near the search field. Pair with per-card content tags (Mature / Mild / etc.) like Janitor's red warning pills for borderline content.

21 Group chat / multi-character

Character.AI	Single character per chat
PolyBuzz	Multi-character RP within a single bubble (not real group chat)
Janitor	Single character
Kindroid	Group chat hint in scenario context
WSUP today	

"GROUP CHAT" link prominent in sidebar — only platform with first-class group chat

RECOMMENDATION

Promote group chat further. Add a "Group Chats" rail on Explore alongside the character grid. It's a moat — competitors don't have it. Treat it as a marketing-grade differentiator.

22 Gamification depth

Character.AI	None visible
PolyBuzz	Chat count on cards only
Janitor	Chat count on cards only
Kindroid	Chat + user count on cards
WSUP today	

Leaderboard cup icon + #rank on every card + Top Creator badge + credits balance + streak

RECOMMENDATION

Strongest gamification in the field. One missing affordance: **make ranks tappable** (link to leaderboard scoped to that category). Today rank is decorative — making it interactive activates the layer.

23 Voice / multimodal

Character.AI	Voice setting in right-panel drawer
PolyBuzz	Not visible (Generate Image is a separate sidebar flow, disconnected from chat)
Janitor	Not visible
Kindroid	Mic IS the primary composer button (huge purple, voice-first)
WSUP today	

Mic + voice playback on AI bubbles + **per-message image-gen from text** — broadest multimodal action set in the field

RECOMMENDATION

Multimodal is actually a moat for WSUP, not a gap. Image-gen-from-message is unique in the field; voice is matched only by Kindroid. The work is positioning, not feature: (a) make the mic icon more visually prominent like Kindroid for users who prefer voice; (b) add a small “Generated by AI” affordance / brief copy near the image-gen icon so first-time users discover it; (c) consider a “Voice mode” toggle in chat chrome that swaps the composer into voice-first layout. All three are positioning moves on existing capability.

WHAT NOT TO IMPORT

Anti-patterns to avoid

Competitive analysis isn't only about what to copy. Some patterns from these platforms would hurt WSUP if imported wholesale. Calling them out so they don't sneak into the roadmap.

PolyBuzz's “Create your Webtoon Series” hero banner. Too aggressive, breaks the clean aesthetic. WSUP's existing promo placement (sidebar Generate Images card) is more elegant. Don't trade quiet polish for shouty promo banners.

Janitor's pagination (148 pages of characters). Clunky vs. infinite scroll. Keep WSUP's infinite scroll; import Janitor's *filters and corpus signal* without the pagination model.

Kindroid's cinematic full-bleed title overlays on every card. Risks design system noise — every card screaming for attention dilutes the moments where attention is actually warranted. Hero treatment for ONE card (the #1 trending) is the sweet spot, not all cards.

Character.AI's deeply-nested settings drawer in chat (7 menu items). WSUP's character-profile-as-right-sidebar is a more inviting pattern. Don't replace it with a settings list — keep the character at center.

PolyBuzz's 16-category pill rail at the top of home. Overwhelming for cold-start users. WSUP currently

has fewer categories than PolyBuzz — resist the pull to add more. Quality of categorization > quantity.

Kindroid's provocative copy on every card ("What happens when you knock up your BFF?"). High click-through energy, but it sets a tone that may not match WSUP's brand range. Use provocative titles deliberately on featured cards, not as the default treatment.

Priority roadmap

Ordered by impact × effort. The top 5 are the “ship within this quarter” tier; the rest sit in the backlog with intentional sequencing logic. Effort estimates are surface-level UX scope only — engineering scope may differ.

Tier 1 — Ship this quarter (high impact, low effort)

1 Tag pills on character cards (Dimension 5)

Every other platform has them. Lowest-effort, biggest-impact. Pull tags from existing character metadata or add a 5-pill cap to the character schema. ~1 day UX scope.

2 Branch chat from here (Dimension 12)

Single new entry in the per-message 3-dot menu next to existing Edit AI msg and Copy. Forks the conversation at that message into a new chat — CAI's killer feature long-session users depend on. ~1-2 days UX scope; engineering needs to wire the branch + fresh-chat-from-state flow.

3 AI disclaimer footer + tappable persona divider (Dimensions 10, 13)

Subtle persistent footer on /chat (“AI-generated, may not be accurate”); persona divider becomes a button that opens persona-switcher sheet. Both are surface-level — ~1 day UX scope combined.

4 Welcome greeting + Stories rail on Explore (Dimensions 4, 18)

“Welcome back, {name}” above the category pills; Stories rail (CAI's Scenes pattern) above or below the character grid. ~2 days UX scope.

5 Tappable category-scoped ranks (Dimension 22)

Today “#75 Rank” on a card is decorative. Make it a link to the leaderboard scoped to that character's category. ~half-day UX scope.

Tier 2 — Next quarter (high impact, medium effort)

1 Two-axis discovery filters + corpus signal (Dimensions 3, 8)

Following / Trending / All + 24h / Weekly time toggle. “Showing X of N characters” below the filter row. Requires backend support for time-windowed trending data.

2 AI-assist on composer (sparkle icon expansion) (Dimension 14)

Sparkle icon → popover with "Enhance my draft" / "Write something for me." Janitor's pattern. UX is light; engineering is the cost (it's another LLM call).

3 Premium tier model pill in chat header (Dimensions 15, 17)

"Standard ↑" pill that opens model-tier selector with Premium gated. Even pre-launch primes users for the upgrade moment. Pairs with monetization roadmap.

4 Verified ✓ on creator @handles + persistent search (Dimensions 7, 2)

Verified badge for Top Creators surfaced at the card level. Persistent search field in sidebar OR sticky-on-scroll search bar on Explore.

5 First-run cold-start triage band (Dimension 19)

4 mood cards (Friend / Boyfriend / Adventure / Just chat) for first-time visitors. Hides after 3 visits. Onboarding scaffold that competitors lack.

Tier 3 — Backlog (lean-into moats)

1 Group Chats rail on Explore (Dimension 21)

Lean into the moat. Group chat is unique to WSUP — treat it as a marketing-grade differentiator with its own discovery surface.

2 Voice mode toggle in chat header (Dimension 23)

For users who prefer voice, swap composer to voice-first layout. Kindroid's voice prominence is the reference.

3 Recent chats grouped by recency (Dimension 1)

"Today" / "This week" / "Older" section headers in the sidebar recent-chats list. Cleans up the long-tail noise.

4 Hero card with cinematic treatment on Explore (Dimension 6)

One hero card — the #1 trending of the day — with Kindroid-style bold-title overlay. Single hero, not all cards. Uses the cinematic energy without breaking the clean aesthetic.

SUMMARY

The shape of the gap

WSUP's chat experience is competitive with Character.AI on most dimensions and ahead on persona, group chat, gamification depth, author-voice formatting, and **in-chat multimodal action set** (image-gen-from-message + voice). The gap is concentrated in **discovery** — where users browse, filter, and find characters before they ever start a chat.

The five Tier-1 recommendations above are designed to close the most visible parts of that gap (tag pills, search persistence, personalization scaffolding, story discoverability) without compromising the chat-experience strengths. The Tier-2 set adds power features that make WSUP defensible against the established players (multi-axis filters, AI-assist, premium tier). Tier 3 doubles down on the moats.

The single biggest near-term opportunity is **tag pills on character cards** — one or two days of UX work, a property every other platform has, and the change with the largest discovery-quality impact relative to effort.

NEXT STEP

Suggest a 30-min PM/UX sync to triage the Tier 1 list against current sprint commitments. Two of the five (tag pills, AI disclaimer + tappable persona) are small enough to slot into a hot-fix sprint; the other three need a dedicated week.

Prepared by Arpit Yadav, UX, WSUP. May 4, 2026. Document version 1.0. All competitive screenshots captured from publicly accessible product surfaces. WSUP screenshots are from the dev-handoff design build (May 4, 2026 commit). For questions, comments, or to suggest additional dimensions to analyze, reply directly.